James Talarico Wins Texas Senate Seat, a First for Democrats Since 1988

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Democrat James Talarico has won a Senate race in Texas, becoming the first Democrat to win a U.S. Senate seat in the state since 1988.

Talarico, a former schoolteacher and state **legislator**, defeated Republican Ken Paxton. His victory helped Democrats take full control of Congress in a night of wins across the country.

Talarico was little known nationally until last year. He made the rising cost of living a central theme of his campaign. Paxton, who campaigned alongside President Trump several times, argued that Talarico's views were too **progressive** for Texas.

Supporters at a watch party in Austin, the state capital, celebrated loudly when television projections called the race for Talarico. "We just proved that all the money in the world is no match for the people of Texas," he told them, referring to the huge spending in the race.

The contest became the most expensive U.S. Senate race in history, with more than half a billion dollars spent. Billionaire Elon Musk gave $158 million to a political group supporting Paxton, a point Talarico raised often in his attacks on Paxton's campaign.

In another surprise, two members of the Bush family, a Republican political **dynasty** with deep Texas roots, backed Talarico.

For decades, a Democrat winning statewide in Texas had seemed out of reach. Texas, the nation's second most **populous** state, has long been a **stronghold** of conservatism, and its Republican policies are often copied elsewhere.

Talarico compared his unlikely odds to the biblical story of David and Goliath. "This win is for every Texan who's ever wondered if anyone is listening," he said.

The same night, Democrat Gina Hinojosa defeated Texas Governor Greg Abbott, the first Democrat to win the governor's race there since the 1990s.

Word Treasure

legislator -- A person elected to help make laws, for example in a state legislature or Congress.

progressive -- Favoring big changes and new ideas in government and society.

dynasty -- A family that keeps power or fame over many years, passing it from one generation to the next.

populous -- Having a lot of people living there; a populous state has a large population.

stronghold -- A place where one group or party is very strong and hard to beat.

Background you need

The U.S. Senate is one of the two chambers of Congress, with two senators from every state, and each seat is filled by a statewide election.

Texas is the nation's second most populous state and has usually voted Republican in statewide races, which is why a Democratic win there is rare.

Big Senate races attract enormous spending because a single seat can help decide which party controls the whole Senate.

Break it down

LEAD: Democrat James Talarico wins a Texas Senate seat, a first for his party since 1988
KEY EVENT: The Texas U.S. Senate race is called for Talarico
+- WHO: James Talarico, a former schoolteacher; Republican Ken Paxton
+- CONTEXT: The most expensive Senate race in history, with more than half a billion dollars spent
REACTION: Supporters in Austin celebrated; Talarico said people power beat big money
OPEN QUESTION: What Talarico's win means for future races in Republican-leaning Texas

Why it matters

A single Senate seat can help decide control of Congress, and this result shows that even the most expensive campaign in history can be beaten by a little-known candidate.

Test what you remember

1. James Talarico is the first Democrat since when to win a U.S. Senate seat in Texas?

- (A) 2018
- (B) 1998
- (C) 1988
- (D) 2008

2. What job did Talarico have before politics?

- (A) Football coach
- (B) Billionaire investor
- (C) Schoolteacher
- (D) Television host

3. Who did Talarico defeat?

- (A) Ken Paxton
- (B) Greg Abbott
- (C) George Bush
- (D) Elon Musk

4. What made the race historic besides its winner?

- (A) It lasted only one day
- (B) It had no advertising at all
- (C) Nobody voted in it
- (D) It was the most expensive U.S. Senate race in history

5. How much did Elon Musk give to a group supporting Paxton?

- (A) $15 million
- (B) $1 billion
- (C) $158 million
- (D) Nothing

6. What theme did Talarico make central to his campaign?

- (A) Lowering the voting age
- (B) Building stadiums
- (C) Space travel
- (D) The rising cost of living

Answer key (try the quiz first!): 1: C 2: C 3: A 4: D 5: C 6: D

Questions to think about

1. James Talarico: Told supporters the win proved all the money in the world is no match for the people of Texas, and compared his odds to David and Goliath.

2. Ken Paxton: Argued that Talarico's views were too progressive for Texas.

MY THOUGHTS (at least 20 words):